UNIVERSITY INTERSCHOLASTIC LEAGUE

Literary Criticism

Region • 2020



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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • Region • 2020

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The large and growing body of literature being produced by American authors whose ethnicities and cultures represent China, Japan, Korea, Vietnam, India, the Philippines, and several other countries is known as

   A) African-American literature.
   B) Asian-American literature.
   C) Chicano and Chicana literature.
   D) Jewish-American literature.
   E) Native American literature.

2. The linguistic principle that describes a complex of relations among consonants in Indo-European languages is

   A) the Baconian Theory.
   B) Freytag's Pyramid.
   C) Grimm's Law.
   D) Ockham's Razor.
   E) scribal error.

3. **Not** a term used to describe poetry that ***fully*** exploits the graphic, visual aspect of writing or printing on the page is the

   A) altar verse.
   B) *carmen figuratum.*
   C) concrete poetry.
   D) echo verse.
   E) shaped verse.

4. The twentieth-century British author of *A Room of One's Own, To the Lighthouse, The Waves,* and *Mrs. Dalloway* is

   A) Nadine Gordimer.
   B) Doris Lessing.
   C) Iris Murdoch.
   D) Muriel Spark.
   E) Virginia Woolf.

5. The winged horse of Grecian fable said to have sprung from Medusa's body at her death that is associated with the inspiration of poetry is

   A) Bucephalus.
   B) Gringolet.
   C) Pegasus.
   D) Phaethon.
   E) Xanthus.

6. A novel such as a sociological novel, a political novel, a problem novel, or a propaganda novel that deals with a problem in a manner that suggests by virtue of its attitude or position, a solution to the problem is known as a

   A) *roman à clef.*
   B) *roman à thèse.*
   C) *roman de geste.*
   D) *roman-fleuve.*
   E) *roman noir.*

7. A lyric poem that is about dawn or that serves as a morning serenade and whose tone is usually joyous is called a(n)

   A) aubade.
   B) *ballade.*
   C) dirge.
   D) lament.
   E) paean.

8. The term that usually refers to the English- and Latin-language pentameter poetic line having the pattern adjective-noun-adjective-noun is

   A) boustrophedonic line.
   B) end-stopped line.
   C) golden line.
   D) pyramidal line.
   E) rhopalic line.

9. The Texas-born playwright whose *The Young Man from Atlanta* earned him the 1995 Pulitzer Prize for Drama is

   A) Edward Albee.
   B) Christopher Durang.
   C) Horton Foote.
   D) Thornton Wilder.
   E) Tennessee Williams.

10. The system of social and political organization that prevailed in Western Europe during much of the medieval period is

    A) aestheticism.
    B) archaism.
    C) barbarism.
    D) determinism.
    E) feudalism.

11. The gathering of writers and thinkers, many of whom lived in a residential district near central London after which the group takes its name, counting among its membership Virginia Woolf, Lytton Strachey, E. M. Forster, and John Maynard Keynes, among others, is the

A) Bloomsbury Group.
B) Bluestockings.
C) Fugitives.
D) Knickerbocker Group.
E) Scriblerus Club.

12. The Swedish poet, translator, and psychologist who received the 2011 Nobel Prize for Literature is

A) Grazia Deledda.
B) Anatole France.
C) Gerhart Hauptmann.
D) Henryk Sienkiewicz.
E) Tomas Gösta Tranströmer.

13. The convention much used in verse rhetorically asking "Where are those who were before us?" is known as the

A) *carpe diem* formula.
B) *in medias res* formula.
C) *memento mori* formula.
D) *ubi sunt* formula.
E) *verbum infans* formula.

14. The name of the diacritical mark (˘) used to indicate a short syllable in the scansion of quantitative verse and an unstressed syllable in accentual-syllabic verse is

A) breve.
B) clerihew.
C) diastole.
D) lemniscus.
E) macron.

15. The early nineteenth-century New England literary group that includes William Cullen Bryant and John Greenleaf Whittier, named for an image that suggests warmth and domesticity as well as their northern environment, is the

A) Fireside Poets.
B) Hartford Wits.
C) Knickerbocker Group.
D) Muckrakers.
E) New York School.

16. The specific figure of speech in which an idea is expressed by offering two components as though they were independent and connecting them with a coordinating conjunction rather than subordinating one part to the other (a specific type of the general trope *sleight of "and"*) is known as

A) caesura.
B) chiasmus.
C) hendiadys.
D) paradiastole.
E) polysyndeton.

17. The twentieth-century American author of *The Old Man and the Sea* and *A Farewell to Arms* is

A) Henry Adams.
B) Saul Bellow.
C) Theodore Dreiser.
D) Ralph Ellison.
E) Ernest Hemingway.

18. The term used metaphorically as a critical standard by Matthew Arnold to detect the presence or absence of high poetic quality is (the)

A) aesthetic distance.
B) alienation effect.
C) jumping the shark.
D) objective correlative.
E) touchstone.

19. **Not** among postmodern writers who have experimented with form and aesthetic surfaces, as well as with themes of alienation and asocialism, and whose protagonists are often antiheroes, is

A) Donald Barthelme.
B) John Fowles.
C) Thomas Pynchon.
D) Alain Robbe-Grillet.
E) Robert Lewis Stevenson.

20. A type of word formed by telescoping two words into one, as the making of "squarson" from "squire" and "parson," "smog" from "smoke" and "fog," and "muppet" from "marionette" and "puppet," is a(n)

A) allelograph.
B) correption.
C) fractal.
D) portmanteau word.
E) synaeresis.

21. The term applied to writing that consists of little more than a series of incidents, each succeeding the other, and having no particularly logical arrangement or complication is

A) cycle.
B) episodic structure.
C) Freytag's pyramid.
D) hermeneutic circle.
E) prolepsis.

22. The group of literary and scientific people in and around Cambridge and Boston in the mid-nineteenth century who came together for social intercourse and good conversation, at irregular intervals, is

A) the Brahmins.
B) The Literary Club.
C) the Roundheads.
D) the Saturday Club.
E) the Transcendental Club.

23. The term for a literary form that burlesques the epic by treating a trivial subject in the "grand style" or uses the epic formulas to make a trivial subject ridiculous by ludicrously overstating it is

A) art epic.
B) folk epic.
C) legend.
D) mock epic.
E) saga.

24. The author of the Middle English masterpieces *The Book of the Duchess, Troilus and Criseyde, House of Fame, The Parlement of Foules,* and *The Canterbury Tales* is

A) Geoffrey Chaucer.
B) William Langland.
C) Thomas Mallory.
D) Thomas More.
E) William of Ockham.

25. A sustained and formal poem setting forth meditations on death or another solemn theme is a(n)

A) elegy.
B) encomium.
C) eulogy.
D) paean.
E) threnody.

26. A figure of speech used for so long that it is taken in its denotative sense only, without the conscious comparison to a physical object it once conveyed, is known as a(n)

A) archaism.
B) dead metaphor.
C) false etymology.
D) Hobson-Jobson.
E) silent correction.

27. Set during the American Civil War and Reconstruction and often referred to as the American epic, the romance novel *Gone with the Wind*'s success garnered the 1937 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for

A) Willa Cather.
B) Margaret Mitchell.
C) Julia Peterkin.
D) Katherine Anne Porter.
E) Edith Wharton.

28. **Not** the eighteenth- or nineteenth-century literary period in which historical and religious concerns, ***or*** the romantic spirit, ***or*** pragmatic verisimilitude characterizes the literature is the

A) Colonial Period.
B) Period of Confessional Self.
C) Realistic Period.
D) Revolutionary and Early National Period.
E) Romantic Period.

29. The environmental activist known as the poet laureate of deep ecology who received the 1975 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for his collection of poems and essays entitled *Turtle Island* is

A) Stephen Dunn.
B) Philip Levine.
C) Paul Muldoon.
D) Gary Snyder.
E) Mark Strand.

30. The unit of rhythm in verse that is integral to the scansion of a line of poetry is known as (the)

A) foot.
B) meter.
C) stress.
D) syllable.
E) syncopation.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-36 are associated with William Shakespeare's *The Tragedy of Othello, The Moor of Venice*.
Items 37-42 are associated with Kurt Vonnegut, Jr.'s *Player Piano*.
Items 43-50 are associated with Percy Bysshe Shelley's poetry (selected).

31. Early in Shakespeare's *The Tragedy of Othello, The Moor of Venice*, the character introduced as "a great arithmetician, / [. . .] / A fellow almost damned in a fair wife, / That never set a squadron in the field, / Nor the division of a battle knows / More than a spinster" is
    A) Brabantio.
    B) Cassio.
    C) Lodovico.
    D) Montano.
    E) Roderigo.

32. The response "But words are words. I never yet did hear / That the bruised heart was pierced through the ear" reveals the exhausted patience of
    A) Brabantio.
    B) Cassio.
    C) Iago.
    D) Othello.
    E) Roderigo.

33. The transumptive question "What ribs of oak, when mountains melt on them, / Can hold the mortise?" constitutes an assessment of the overwhelming power of a
    A) battle.
    B) conflagration.
    C) duel.
    D) ship.
    E) storm.

34. Othello's verbal confirmation with Cassio, "Do you triumph, Roman? Do you triumph?" is a
    A) biblical allusion.
    B) historical allusion.
    C) literary allusion.
    D) mythological allusion.
    E) topical allusion.

35. The aside "This is the night / That either makes me or fordoes me quite" is spoken by
    A) Cassio.
    B) Desdemona.
    C) Emilia.
    D) Iago.
    E) Othello.

36. Calling out, ironically, to Iago, "Reputation, reputation, reputation! O, I have lost my reputation! I have lost the immortal part of myself and what remains is bestial. / My reputation, Iago, my reputation!" is
    A) Cassio.
    B) Gratiano.
    C) Lodovico.
    D) Montano.
    E) Othello.

37. In Vonnegut's fantasy *Player Piano*, the system that "had so cut waste and duplication" that it was "often cited as one of the few concrete benefits of the war" is
    A) the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.
    B) the Dystopian Chess Competition.
    C) the National Manufacturing Council.
    D) the Reconstruction and Reclamation Corps.
    E) the Reeks and Wrecks.

38. Putting a pen knife to the sweatband of his cap, one of the Reeks and Wrecks reveals the level of human ingenuity being wasted by repairing Paul's car's
    A) automatic transmission.
    B) flat tire.
    C) fuel pump.
    D) water pump.
    E) windshield fluid reservoir.

39. Halyard's disdain for the man who pronounced "order out of chaos" as "order out of koze" is disdain for
    A) Checker Charley.
    B) EPICAC.
    C) President Jonathan Lynn.
    D) Khashdrahr Miasma.
    E) Dr. Paul Proteus.

40. Claiming a leadership role in the revolt named after an Indigenous Americans' fight "for the old values" is
    A) Edward Finnerty.
    B) Edgar Hagstrohm.
    C) Rudy Hertz.
    D) Alfred Planck.
    E) Paul Proteus.

41. "If policy is iron-clad, why not let a machine make the decisions? Policy isn't thinkin', it's a reflex" is essentially Bud Calhoun's answer to the

A) advancement of *Takaru*.
B) cost of human employment.
C) lack of mouse-finding machines.
D) need for computerized checkers players.
E) role of competition at the Meadows.

42. "Just because they were born in the same part of the world as I was, that doesn't mean I have to come down here and wallow with them" pretty much sums up

A) Katharine Finch.
B) Delores Hagstrohm.
C) Wanda Hagstrohm.
D) Janice Kroner.
E) Anita Proteus.

Items 43-46 refer to Percy Bysshe Shelley's

Mutability

We are as clouds that veil the midnight moon;
How restlessly they speed, and gleam, and quiver,
Streaking the darkness radiantly!—yet soon
Night closes round, and they are lost forever:

Or like forgotten lyres, whose dissonant strings
Give various response to each varying blast,
To whose frail frame no second motion brings
One mood or modulation like the last.

We rest.—A dream has power to poison sleep;
We rise.—One wandering thought pollutes the day;
We feel, conceive or reason, laugh or weep;
Embrace fond woe, or cast our cares away:

It is the same!—For, be it joy or sorrow,
The path of its departure still is free:
Man's yesterday may ne'er be like his morrow;
Nought may endure but Mutability.

43. Percy Bysshe Shelley's "Mutability" opens with a comparison, the vehicle of which is developed into an independent aesthetic object that for the moment upstages the tenor; this type of comparison is known as a(n)

A) controlling image.
B) dead metaphor.
C) diminishing metaphor.
D) epic simile.
E) pleonasm.

44. The theme of Shelley's "Mutability," especially as it appears in the final line of the sonnet, "Nought may endure but Mutability," is an example of (a/n)

A) ambiguity.
B) antithesis.
C) equivoque.
D) hyperbole.
E) paradox.

45. The continuation of both the sense and grammatical construction of line 4 on to the next verse and of line 12 on to the next verse constitute (a/n)

A) enjambment.
B) fused line.
C) inversion.
D) run-on line.
E) truncation.

46. Lines 2 and 4, as well as lines 13 and 15, are characterized by

A) compound rhyme.
B) eye rhyme.
C) feminine rhyme.
D) leonine rhyme.
E) masculine rhyme.

Items 47-50 refer to Percy Bysshe Shelley's

[Lift not the painted veil]

Lift not the painted veil which those who live
Call Life: though unreal shapes be pictured there,
And it but mimic all we would believe
With colours idly spread,—behind, lurk Fear
And Hope, twin Destinies; who ever weave
Their shadows, o'er the chasm, sightless and drear.
I knew one who had lifted it—he sought,
For his lost heart was tender, things to love,
But found them not, alas! nor was there aught
The world contains, the which he could approve.
Through the unheeding many he did move,
A splendour among shadows, a bright blot
Upon this gloomy scene, a Spirit that strove
For truth, and like the Preacher found it not.

47. The *painted veil* of Shelley's poem's first line is a(n)

A) epitaph.
B) euphemism.
C) kenning.
D) metaphor.
E) tautology.

48. In Percy Bysshe Shelley's "[Lift not the painted veil]," the speaker projects, through the "one who had lifted" the veil (line 7), a certain degree of

A) disappointment.
B) excitement.
C) misunderstanding.
D) revulsion.
E) uncertainty.

49. The "twin Destinies" of lines 4 and 5—the abstractions being treated as concrete things—should be recognized as examples of

A) allegory.
B) litotes.
C) objectification.
D) pathetic fallacy.
E) reification.

50. The *Preacher* of Shelley's final line finds full effect as a

A) biblical allusion.
B) classical allusion.
C) historical allusion.
D) literary allusion.
E) topical allusion.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism

Items 51-55 refer to E. E. Cummings's

since feeling is first

since feeling is first
who pays any attention
to the syntax of things
will never wholly kiss you;
wholly to be a fool
while Spring is in the world

my blood approves,
and kisses are a better fate
than wisdom
lady i swear by all flowers. Don't cry
—the best gesture of my brain is less than
your eyelids' flutter which says

we are for each other: then
laugh, leaning back in my arms
for life's not a paragraph

And death i think is no parenthesis

51. The controlling image of E. E. Cummings's "since feeling is first" is the conceit involving *syntax* (line 3), which is continued in lines

A) 6 and 7.
B) 7 and 8.
C) 8 and 9.
D) 11 and 12.
E) 15 and 16.

52. The use of *Spring* in the speaker's declaration "wholly to be a fool / while Spring is in the world / my blood approves" (lines 5-6) is

A) didactic.
B) elegiac.
C) hyperbolic.
D) metaphorical.
E) vatic.

53. The comparison found in lines 11-12 argues the supremacy of

A) brains over eyelashes.
B) emotion over reason.
C) flowers over crying.
D) gestures over flutters.
E) wisdom over blood.

54. Death, in the form of rationality, as an interruption of feeling (line 16) is understood in terms of

A) allusion.
B) fatalism.
C) litotes.
D) semiotics.
E) syntax.

55. The apostrophe (begins line 10) declaring, "I swear by all flowers"—in the context of the comparison between the "best gesture of [his] brain" and her "eyelids' flutter," the intensity of both thought and feelings, no doubt, fading once "Spring" is over—is a reinforcement of the poem's failure at syntax in the face of feeling, which "is first," reinforces the speaker's

A) determination to make her laugh.
B) failure to follow the rules of punctuation.
C) ironic understanding of life.
D) muddled attempt to impress her.
E) wholly foolishly anaphoric wisdom.

Items 56-65 refer to John Frederick Nims's

Love Poem

My clumsiest dear, whose hands shipwreck vases,
At whose quick touch all glasses chip and ring,
Whose palms are bulls in china, burs in linen,
And have no cunning with any soft thing

Except all ill-at-ease fidgeting people:
The refugee uncertain at the door
You make at home; deftly you steady
The drunk clambering on his undulant floor.

Unpredictable dear, the taxi drivers' terror,
Shrinking from far headlights pale as a dime
Yet leaping before apoplectic streetcars—
Misfit in any space. And never on time.

A wrench in clocks and the solar system. Only
With words and people and love you move at ease;
In traffic of wit expertly maneuver
And keep us, all devotion, at your knees.

Forgetting your coffee spreading on our flannel,
Your lipstick grinning on our coat,
So gaily in love's unbreakable heaven
Our souls on glory of spilt bourbon float.

56. The combination of sense and grammatical construction of line 4 to line 5 of Frederick Nims's "Love Poem" is an example of

A) enjambment.
B) fused rhyme.
C) run-on line.
D) tag-line.
E) truncation.

57. The poem's tone, beginning with the first line and concluding with the final stanza's invocation is

A) abusively critical.
B) condescendingly loving.
C) gratifyingly complimentary.
D) irreverently passive.
E) lightheartedly hurtful.

58. The imagery of "apoplectic streetcars" and, perhaps, "lipstick grinning" (lines 11 and 18) is strengthened by

A) apostrophe.
B) hyperbole.
C) metonymy.
D) personification.
E) reification.

59. In line 13 of Nims's poem, the stacking and compressing of the implied metaphor, the syllepsis, and the hyperbole that contribute to "A wrench in clocks and the solar system" together comprise an instance of

A) conceit.
B) litotes.
C) metalepsis.
D) metaphor.
E) metonymy.

60. The theme of Nims's "Love Poem" is

A) delight in the shortcomings of one's lover.
B) music can make life better.
C) triumph over impatience.
D) women drivers have difficulty with many things.
E) writing poetry is good couples therapy.

Items 61-65 are found on the next page.

Items 61-65 refer to Emily Brontë's

The Wind, I Hear It Sighing

The wind I hear it sighing
With Autumn's saddest sound;
Withered leaves all thick are lying
As spring-flowers on the ground.

This dark night has won me
To wander far away;
Old feelings gather fast upon me
Like vultures round their prey.

Kind were they once and cherished,
But cold and cheerless now;
I would their lingering shades had perished
When their light left my brow.

'Tis like old age pretending
The softness of a child,
My altered, hardened spirit bending
To meet their fancies wild.

Yet could I with past pleasures
Past woe's oblivion buy,
That by the death of my dearest treasures
My deadliest pains might die,

O then another daybreak
Might haply dawn above,
Another summer gild my cheek,
My soul, another love.

61. The second and fourth stanzas of Emily Brontë's "The Wind, I Hear It Sighing" rely on

A) hyperbole.
B) litotes.
C) metaphors.
D) similes.
E) tautology.

62. The first and third lines of the first, third, fourth, and fifth stanza exhibit

A) assonance rhyme.
B) compound rhyme.
C) eye rhyme.
D) masculine rhyme.
E) triple rhyme.

63. Throughout Brontë's poem, the auditory imagery is reinforced by

A) consonance.
B) dissonance.
C) onomatopoeia.
D) sigmatism and alliteration.
E) syncopation.

64. The poem's mood might be best understood as

A) foreboding.
B) reflective.
C) remorseful.
D) unapologetic.
E) wistful.

65. *Brow* (line 12) and *cheek* (line 23), in representing aspects of the persona's encounter with life, perhaps, worry and happiness, respectively, reflect the poet's effective use of

A) allegory.
B) imagery.
C) metonymy.
D) pun.
E) simile.

Required Tie-Breaking Essay Prompt
on the Next Page

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie. Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Carl Sandburg's "Hangman at Home" and offer a discussion of the central concern, especially how Sandburg handles it.

The Hangman at Home

What does the hangman think about
When he goes home at night from work?
When he sits down with his wife and
Children for a cup of coffee and a
Plate of ham and eggs, do they ask
Him if it was a good day's work
And everything went well, or do they
Stay off some topics and talk about
The weather, baseball, politics
And the comic strips in the papers
And the movies? Do they look at his
Hands when he reaches for the coffee
Or the ham and eggs? If the little
Ones say, Daddy, play horse, here's
A rope—does he answer like a joke:
I seen enough rope for to-day?
Or does his face light up like a
Bonfire of joy and does he say:
It's a good and dandy world we live
In. And if a white face moon looks
In through a window where a baby girl
Sleeps and the moon gleams mix with
Baby ears and baby hair—the hangman—
How does he act then? It must be easy
For him. Anything is easy for a hangman,
I guess.

1920